

CHAPTER 11 — The Showing

Zoe's hand found the strap of her backpack again.

It had been happening for most of the drive: fingers closing around the webbing, tightening, loosening, then returning as though the bag might disappear if she stopped checking it was there. Elias had noticed the first time. By the fourth, he had learned not to mention it.

"Day four," she said, "is why I still have this. And why I'm here at all, instead of still in that house."

She pulled the backpack closer to her stomach.

They came for her early, before she had time to become afraid in any organised way.

The older woman entered carrying a small plastic tray. She was different from the one who had recited the rules. Brisker. More carefully dressed. Her hair was pinned back so tightly that it seemed to pull the expression from her face.

On the tray sat a paper cup and a folded square of white cloth.

"Drink this," she said. "It'll help you relax before the showing."

The word landed with all the others Zoe had collected over the previous three days: buyer, original number, prepared, showing. Words everyone else understood and nobody would explain.

She thought of the older girl's mouth barely moving beneath the unbroken light.

Don't eat anything they give you before it. Don't drink anything either, if you can help it.

Zoe took the cup.

Her hand shook. She let it. Nobody expected a frightened child to have steady hands.

The liquid smelled faintly of orange with something medicinal underneath. She lifted it to her lips, tipped her head back and allowed enough into her mouth to wet her tongue. Bitterness spread

immediately. She held the rest against the inside of her cheek, trapped behind her back teeth, while the woman watched the bottom of the cup rise.

"All of it."

Zoe swallowed once.

Not the liquid.

Only air.

Then she lowered the empty cup.

"Good girl."

The woman took it and used the white cloth to wipe a drop from Zoe's chin, not gently or cruelly, but with the impersonal care of someone cleaning a mark from glass.

The door closed.

Zoe crossed to the sink, bent low and spat the liquid into the basin. She turned on the tap and rinsed the orange trace away before it could settle. Then she scooped water into her mouth, swilled once and spat again.

The bitterness remained behind her teeth.

There was no way to know how much she had swallowed by accident.

She looked at herself in the small mirror above the basin. Her face looked pale and detached, her eyes too bright within it. She let her mouth hang open. Let her shoulders sag. Tried to make her gaze slide past her own reflection rather than meet it.

The first version looked like acting.

The second looked frightened.

By the fourth, she looked vacant enough to frighten herself.

When the lock turned again, she was sitting on the edge of the bed with her hands loose between her knees.

Two women entered. One carried a comb. The other carried Zoe's

school uniform on a hanger.

For a moment, seeing it was worse than seeing unfamiliar clothes would have been.

Her white shirt had been washed and pressed. The blazer was brushed clean. Even the tie had been retied into a neat knot and loosened just enough to pass over her head. The uniform looked ready for an ordinary Friday morning, as though it had been waiting patiently for her to finish whatever interruption had kept her from school.

“Stand up,” one of the women said.

Zoe obeyed too slowly.

They changed her without asking her to help. The shirt was buttoned to the throat. Her tie was straightened. One woman brushed her hair while the other inspected her face, lifting her chin towards the light and turning it first one way, then the other.

“She looks tired.”

“That’s the point.”

“Not too tired.”

A thumb pressed beneath Zoe’s eye, testing the skin there.

“She’ll pass.”

They spoke over her and around her, never to her except to issue instructions.

Chin up.

Arms down.

Turn.

Wait.

The woman with the comb caught a knot and pulled hard enough to bring water into Zoe’s eyes.

“Don’t start,” she said.

Zoe let her focus drift towards the wall.

She was learning that people saw what they expected to see.

A sedated child did not glare.

A sedated child did not calculate distances.

A sedated child did not notice that one woman wore a ring of keys at her left hip and the other checked the corridor before opening the door.

So Zoe noticed everything and made it look like nothing.

"You faked it," Elias said.

He kept his eyes on the road. When he spoke again, his voice had lost some of its earlier distance.

"I tried."

"You succeeded."

"Some of it got into me." Zoe rubbed her tongue against the back of her teeth as though the taste might still be there. "Not enough to put me out. Enough to make everything feel half a second late."

"That could have gone badly."

"Everything could have gone badly."

Elias accepted that with a small movement of his head.

"Why risk it?"

"Because I didn't know what was coming," she said. "And not knowing was worse when I couldn't think."

They took her downstairs by a route she had not used before.

The house changed as they moved through it. The rooms where the children slept and waited had cheap paint, bare bulbs and furniture chosen to survive damage. This part had carpet thick enough to swallow footsteps. Framed prints hung on the walls. A vase of artificial white

flowers stood on a table beneath a mirror, the sort of arrangement that might have belonged in a private clinic or an expensive solicitor's office.

Nothing in it admitted what the house was.

The showing room was colder than the corridor.

Bright panels had been fitted into the ceiling, too white and too even. One wall was covered from skirting board to ceiling by darkened glass, too perfect and too black to belong in an ordinary room. A square of pale tape marked a position on the carpet. A single chair stood against the far wall, beyond reach of the taped box.

The brisk woman guided Zoe into the square.

"Feet together."

Zoe moved them.

"Hands by your sides."

She lowered them.

The woman adjusted the fall of her blazer, tugged one sleeve down and lifted Zoe's chin with two fingers.

"Keep looking forward."

Zoe looked at the darkened glass.

It returned a schoolgirl in a clean uniform: small, pale, exhausted, her hair brushed smooth. No locked doors. No barred window. No children in the room with too many chairs. Nothing to explain why she stood beneath lights while unseen adults decided something about her.

A faint click came from behind the glass.

Then a man's voice, softened by a speaker hidden somewhere above her.

"Thirteen?"

The woman answered without turning. "Recently."

Another voice asked, "Documentation?"

“Verified.”

“Original as well as placement?”

The woman paused.

Only briefly, but Zoe felt it.

“The original record is held on site.”

A third voice, a woman this time, said, “Medical history?”

“Complete.”

“Any current medication?”

“No.”

The questions continued in the same calm register.

Languages.

Schooling.

Travel documents.

Whether she had been placed before.

Whether the number had been used across borders.

The words did not form a whole picture for Zoe, but the tone did. They were inspecting her the way Brian inspected a second-hand car before buying it: not because he cared how it felt, but because he wanted to know what problems came with it.

Her knees began to tremble.

She locked them.

The room tilted a fraction to the left. The small amount of liquid she had swallowed seemed to move behind her eyes. She concentrated on the lower edge of the glass, where it met the skirting board.

There was a tiny chip near the corner.

A flaw no one had bothered to repair.

She fixed herself to it.

A voice behind the glass said, "Have her turn."

The woman placed a hand on Zoe's shoulder and rotated her.

"Slower," the voice said.

Zoe let her feet drag. Let her head follow too late. She made herself into what they thought they had made her.

"Open her mouth."

The woman pressed Zoe's chin down and told her to open. A light passed briefly across her teeth.

"Enough," someone said.

There was movement behind the glass.

Papers shifting.

A chair scraping.

Then the first man's voice again, no longer quite so calm.

"This number doesn't match the transfer sheet."

The brisk woman's fingers tightened once on Zoe's shoulder.

A different man answered from farther away, not through the speaker.

"The transfer number is current. The original record carries the first identifier."

"Then bring me the original record."

"You've seen the verification."

"I paid for full verification."

"You paid for a summary."

A door opened somewhere behind the glass. Footsteps moved into the corridor outside. The woman beside Zoe looked towards the sound, then back at the glass.

“Stay,” she said.

She need not have bothered.

Zoe was already standing exactly where they had placed her.

The woman left.

For several seconds, nothing happened.

Then voices rose deeper in the house.

“You don’t get access to the archive.”

“I get access to the record I paid to verify.”

“You get what was agreed.”

A heavy impact shook something in the adjoining room. Another voice cut in, sharper, ordering both men to stop. Furniture scraped. A door slammed. Glass broke with a hard, bright crack.

The speaker above Zoe hissed and went dead.

She remained inside the taped square.

Five breaths.

Ten.

Her heart beat so violently that the edges of her vision pulsed with it.

She watched the darkened glass.

No movement.

No change in the light.

If someone remained behind it, they saw a drugged girl waiting where she had been told.

Zoe let her head drop.

Counted another five.

Then she raised it.

The corridor beyond the open door was empty.

"You waited," Elias said.

"I was scared the glass still had someone behind it."

"Good reason."

"It didn't feel good. It felt like standing there while the only chance I might ever get disappeared."

"Waiting and freezing aren't the same thing."

Zoe looked at him in the mirror.

"How do you know?"

Elias took a moment before answering.

"Because one has an end you choose."

Zoe stepped out of the square.

Her right foot landed badly. The floor seemed to shift beneath it and she caught the doorframe before she fell. The drug had not made her helpless, but it had not left her untouched either.

The shouting continued somewhere towards the front of the house. A man swore. Someone else shouted for security.

Two doors down, the archive stood open.

Someone had brought the original folder out in a hurry and never pulled the door closed behind them.

Zoe had seen the room only in fragments before: a green keypad light, the edge of a safe, numbered folders lined with unnatural precision. Now the door was wide enough to show all of it.

The safe stood open.

Hard drives filled its shelves, arranged upright in black cases like a row of teeth. Numbered folders sat in stacks beneath them. An old leather ledger lay closed on the desk, thick enough to stop a door. Beside it, a

laptop displayed a pale screen crowded with boxes and codes Zoe could not read.

A cable ran from the laptop to a small black drive.

The screen showed the same number the adults had argued about in the showing room.

And beside the drive lay an open folder.

A photograph rested on top.

A girl of six or seven, hair in two plaits, laughing at something beyond the edge of the picture.

Zoe stopped breathing.

She had seen the photograph two days earlier on the kitchen counter and recognised herself then. Now, with the folder open and the number exposed on the tab, she understood why it mattered.

The folder was hers.

Not someone else's.

Not a coincidence.

Hers.

The folder had been brought out for the showing. The argument had been about the number written across it.

Zoe crossed the room and took it.

Beside the open folder lay a clear plastic property bag containing the possessions taken from her on the first night: exercise books, a pencil case, a crushed packet of tissues and her backpack, one strap twisted beneath it. A white label on the bag carried the same number as the folder.

Her phone was not inside.

She tore the plastic open.

The backpack smelled faintly of rain and the lavender detergent Helen used at home.

The smell nearly undid her.

She pushed the folder inside.

The shouting moved closer.

Zoe looked at the laptop.

She did not know what was on the attached drive. She knew only that adults had checked it while discussing her records, that the original file and the number had changed the buyers' voices, and that the argument had emptied the showing room and pulled everyone towards the archive.

Whatever was on the drive mattered enough to make them forget her for a few seconds.

That made the drive important.

She pulled the cable free.

The laptop chimed.

Too loud.

Footsteps entered the corridor.

Zoe shoved the drive into the backpack, closed the zip and moved behind the archive door just as a man passed the opening. She saw only the side of his dark jacket and one bloodied hand held close to his chest. He did not look into the room. He was calling for someone, voice ragged with anger, moving towards the showing room.

Zoe waited until his footsteps faded.

Then she ran the other way.

The corridor ended at a narrow service passage.

Cold air touched her face before she saw its source.

At the far end, an exterior door stood open. A wooden crate held it back while two men struggled to move an injured man towards a waiting

vehicle beyond it. One shouted for someone to clear the way. The other

looked down at the blood on his hands.

Neither looked at Zoe.

A woman's voice sounded behind her.

"Where is she?"

Zoe reached the door.

For one terrible second, the backpack caught on the handle.

She pulled hard enough to wrench her shoulder, tore the strap free and stumbled outside.

The daylight was enormous.

The house stood on a quiet residential street lined with clipped hedges and broad driveways. A delivery van was parked opposite. Somewhere nearby, a lawnmower droned. Curtains moved in an upstairs window and settled again.

Nothing looked like escape because nothing looked like captivity.

Zoe ran.

She had no idea which direction led home.

Traffic noise came from downhill.

She followed it.

At the end of the street she turned left, then right, then left again, trying to make it harder for anyone behind her to see where she had gone. The backpack struck her spine with every step. Her school shoes slipped on damp pavement. Twice she looked back and saw no one.

The third time she nearly ran into a parked car.

Her lungs burned.

Her legs had forgotten what running was for.

After several streets, she ducked behind a row of commercial bins and crouched there, fighting for breath, one hand clamped over her mouth. A car passed slowly. She pressed herself against the brick wall until it

moved on.

It was not theirs.

She stayed until she could count ten breaths without losing the number.

Then she walked.

The neighbourhood gave way to a busier road: petrol station, pharmacy, takeaway, traffic lights. The signs meant nothing to her, but buses did. A stop stood beside the pharmacy with a route map scratched beneath its plastic cover.

Most of the place names were unfamiliar.

One was not.

The regional town centre.

She had been there with Helen. School trips changed buses there. From the interchange she could find a route she knew.

The electronic display said twelve minutes.

The wait felt longer than anything since the van door had closed.

When the bus arrived, Zoe stepped aboard and stopped beside the driver.

She had no purse.

No coins.

No pass.

The driver glanced at her uniform, then at the queue behind her.

“Go on,” he said, already looking past her to the next passenger.

That was all.

No alarm.

No questions.

No adult seeing through the clean blazer to the numbered folder and

stolen drive pressed against her back.

Zoe moved down the aisle and sat where she could see the front door reflected in the window.

The bus pulled away.

For the first five minutes she was certain the house would appear around every corner. Then she was certain someone would board at every stop. A man in a dark coat climbed on and her whole body locked before he turned towards an empty seat without looking at her.

Outside, ordinary life continued with an almost insulting calm.

People carried shopping.

Two boys in another school's uniform shoved each other and laughed.

A woman argued into her phone beside a pushchair.

Traffic waited, moved and waited again.

Nobody knew where Zoe had been.

Nobody knew what she carried.

At the town-centre interchange, she stepped down into noise, diesel fumes and a crowd thick enough to hide inside. Electronic boards clicked through destinations. She found a route number she recognised from trips with Helen and stood among a cluster of schoolchildren waiting beneath it.

For the first time since the van door had closed, she looked like every other child around her.

She kept both arms around the backpack.

Her second bus was almost full. She stood for three stops with both arms still wrapped around it, then took a seat when one became free.

Familiar streets began to appear in fragments: the supermarket with the broken letter in its sign, the park where Brian complained about dog owners, the junction before her school.

She could have got off there.

For a moment she imagined walking through the school gates, finding a teacher, saying everything at once before anyone could stop her.

Then she remembered the folder in her bag.

The number instead of her name.

Adults in the house talking about documents, transfers and placements as though every official thing she knew could belong to them too.

Home was closer.

Home was Helen and Brian.

Home was where frightened children were supposed to go.

She stayed on the bus.

By the time she reached her stop, afternoon had thinned towards evening. The sky above the houses was turning the colour of old metal. Her legs shook when she stood, and the driver watched her in the mirror, perhaps wondering if she was ill, perhaps not wondering anything at all.

Zoe stepped down and walked the final streets.

She knew every crack in the pavement.

Every garden wall.

The house with the wind chimes.

The corner where Jackie sometimes waited for her in the mornings, pretending she had arrived by accident.

Her own street appeared.

The porch light was on.

Helen always turned it off before evening to save electricity.

Zoe stopped at the gate.

The house looked exactly as it had four days earlier. Curtains half-drawn. Brian's car in the drive. A plant pot Helen kept meaning to replace leaning beside the step.

She walked to the door and stood before it with one hand raised.

She had passed through that doorway thousands of times without once thinking about what it meant to be allowed back inside.

Then she knocked.

Elias's eyes moved briefly to the backpack in her lap.

"You knew the folder was yours," he said.

"I knew the photograph was me. I knew the number was the same one they'd been arguing about. I didn't understand the rest until later."

"And the drive?"

"I didn't know what was on it." Zoe's fingers tightened around the strap again. "I still don't. Not properly. But it was connected to the computer when they checked my records. They cared enough about the archive to start fighting over who could see it. I thought—"

She stopped.

"What?"

"I thought it might tell me who I was."

Elias looked back to the road.

The motorway noise filled the car: tyres, wind through the narrow gap at the top of his window, the distant complaint of a lorry changing gear behind them.

"It's still in there," he said.

It was not a question.

Zoe nodded.

"I kept both. I never opened the drive. I opened the folder the night before the flight."

Elias's hands rested lightly on the wheel, but the stillness in them had changed.

"Keeping them was a decision," he said.

"It didn't feel like one."

"Most decisions don't feel like decisions while you're making them. You recognised the gap. You took your own file. You took the thing they were protecting. You carried both out."

"I ran because I was scared."

"You can be scared and still choose."

Zoe looked at him properly then.

Her grip on the strap loosened by a fraction.

"I never thought of it that way."

"Most people don't," Elias said. "Doesn't make it less true."

The silence that followed was different from the ones before it.

Not empty. Not demanding. Just shared. "There's more," Zoe said after a while. "I know." Elias kept his eyes on the road. "Take your time."